From First Glance to Goodbye – A Collection

By Sabrina Benaim

it starts (Pg 64)

with a spark that makes static electricity look like longing.
i am spellbound by the smoke billowing from his Belmont
cigarette.
like i am staring at his Belmont cigarette sat
snug between his lips like i wish my name
would. he is so cool. he is like the king of ice cream
sandwiches.
like i wish my tongue was a drawbridge to his castle.
his heart is a stubborn pistachio. like i want to crack it
open.
i want to play his heartstrings like a harp,
or rip out his heartstrings & like braid them into a bracelet.
like decorate me. i want to wear him.

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INTRODUCTION

Sabrina Benaim's Depression and Other Magic Tricks feels like opening an old journal you thought you'd burned. Every page humming with the ghosts of those you once loved too much. She doesn't just talk about loss, she makes the emotions pulse like a heartbeat, and she shows how memories, no matter how much we try to fold them away, keep finding their way back to us. The poems "it starts", "unrequited in nine acts" and "how to fold a memory" take us from love's first glance to its final good-bye.

unrequited in nine acts (Pg 49-51)

the question hangs a hook through my pink cheek. how did you do that thing that you did to my heart?

because isn't the real tragedy how you found yourself in one another. how you took one brief look into the mirror of her, turned around, and walked away?

the girl's arms are empty, but her fists are filled with the laughter of ghosts. watch their fitful ridicule each time she cries over love less real than they are.

there are baseballs falling out of my mouth. each ball a name of a body i reached for in the dark to find myself. a parade of honest names slipped from the grip of my loose

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glove jaw. the love i want is a basketball. i had these thumping in the chest when it is my turn to step up to the plate. i do not swing, i do not swing.

her name is a wooden ship to try and force it into his glass bottle. heart would only break her.

a montage of all the times i wished you had taken my hand and then, when you didn't, and the moment passed a montage of all the places i wished myself far far away to: portland, barcelona, basically any place i have never seen your smile.

what is the name of a place that everyone can see is burning, but no one can feel the effects of the smoke or the heat of the flames except the place? and that place is not a place but a person and that person is the i in my poems. only it's my real-life body that aches, and isn't that love not being able to see the explosion even though you are the one holding the bomb and the bomb is also you?

the girls hair turns to forget-me-nots and time. her bones softened to willow branches, her skin flakes may believe.

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her chest is now a cabinet of well stacked cigar boxes. caskets carrying memories she is slow turning to ash. in lieu of conversation she passes smoke. the girl collect seashells up turns them into bowls filled them with dried lavender and amethyst in hopes of luring someone new. still remembering is her favorite pastime. she cannot hold her heart up without trembling, so she hides it away in bottomless midnight's, which are her grief, but are also her lust. the girl is now a girl who is also a whale full of unoccupied space and it's tragic how she displaces her emptiness with loneliness. how she wants and wants and wants, and needs to know why why the boy might want to live so far away from her now, when his house is just a couple blocks south of ten minutes, and all that space lays still loud as a snails cry. wouldn't i know about crawling up inside oneself?

wouldn't i know about a body full of waiting and a floor clean as a plate in a cupboard holding nine other plates on top of it? how it's also unbearable... holding love. how it makes the girl feel helpless this period of heavy pockets of change her heart is unwilling to make?

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did you hear me? i said i love you. i said i still love you. Still.
. . you.

how to fold a memory (Pg 32-34)

our brains remember the infliction of pain, be it physical,
psychological, or emotional. we remember this hurt as
means to avoid it in the future.

let's start at the beginning.
i remember the shape of my hand held while in yours,
like origami prayer, or flower petals returning home.
i remember the rose petals falling from your fingers,
leading from the doorway to the bedroom like a
trail of breadcrumbs, or drops of blood.
the scent of cinnamon, how you would sprinkle in into my
coffee
like fresh ground snowflakes.
i can't cinnamon in my coffee
without getting hungry for your laughter.
i am hungry for your laughter, but my mouth tastes like the
slow
dissolve of the last i love you that refused to leave it.
i remember the river, how we danced to the sound of it

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rushing,
how you hummed radiohead in harmony.
that song haunts my house of cards, i wish it would
collapse.
i wish i could forget how i got here,
how did i get here? i was carried in the teeth
of your charm, or i walked.
i marched. i was a turning cheek parade.
i wasn't paying attention to the highlighted route,
or there was no map, i got lost.

with every journey back into our past, it becomes
harder
to find our way there.
our brains are constantly rerouting the paths,
rewriting
what we remember.

let's go to the end -
it was by little sugar creek, in the warm kentucky breeze,
we stood off unfolding in silence.
in silence, it's hard o tell what the other person
is thinking without looking them in the eyes.

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you would not look me in the eyes.
so, by little sugar creek, i let the warm breeze reach
you in place of my origami hands.

ever since, i have been practicing forgetting.
i've kissed the sky more times than i ever kissed you.
i inhale purple haze in an attempt to smoke out the correlation
between you and the scent of cinnamon.
i drink as if i am trying to save the world from drowning.
to get my memories so drunk,
they might forget themselves by morning.
but the trauma of daydreaming.
the curse of muscle memory; my body keeps your secrets.

how do i teach my mouth to shake out the reflection
of your etch-a-sketch a smile?
my wrist, to forget the swoops and arcs of your name?
my ears, to hear songs without the ghost of you inside of them?

worse, i cannot tell in these spasms of remembering,
if the past tense keeps slipping in to my present,

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or if my present keeps slipping into the past.
still, my body wears your fingerprints like a home address.
i lose memories like baby teeth, but you
are a stubborn molar, refusing to leave.

we cannot control what we remember,
but we can control how we remember.

i shake cinnamon into my coffee, & i don't think of you.
i write your name over and over so that it no longer has any meaning.
i fold memories of you, craft them paper wings,
in hopes one day they might drift into amnesia,
& you might leave me,
without a trace.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sabrina Benaim
Book: Depression and Other Magic Tricks
ISBN: 978-1943735204
Publisher: Button Poetry
Date (Month/Year): Aug 2017

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

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